Athletics and Attendance

An April 2026 American Enterprise Institute report (n=262,600, Indiana) finds varsity athletes are 12.9 percentage points less likely to be chronically absent than non-athletes (7.7 pp after demographic controls), with an effect ~2× larger for low-income students. In California, LCFF revenue is based on ADA.

NON-ATHLETES

22.9%

Chronic absenteeism rate (≥10% of school days missed). Indiana statewide HS data, 2023–24.

VARSITY ATHLETES

10.0%

−12.9 pp raw / −7.7 pp adjusted for demographics. Three-season athletes = 10.0% (single-season = 15.2%).

LCFF VALUE OF 1 PP ATTENDANCE

~$1.7M+

1% × 14,835 GUHSD ADA = 148 students × ~$11,500–$13,000 LCFF rate per HS ADA.

Effects by student group

Subgroup	Adjusted athlete effect (pp absence reduction)	Notes
Free / Reduced-Price Meal-eligible students	**1.45 pp**	Nearly 2× the effect of 0.74 pp for non-poor students
Black students	**1.32 pp**	vs. White students 0.90 pp
Hispanic / Latino students	**1.27 pp**	vs. White students 0.90 pp
Female students	**1.20 pp**	vs. male students 0.77 pp

> "*It is almost certain that athletes' improved attendance during their sports seasons is predominantly caused by their active sports participation.*"
> — Malkus and Hollon, *An Extra Point for Attendance: The Impact of High School Varsity Athletics on Absenteeism*, American Enterprise Institute, April 8, 2026 (n=262,600 Indiana HS students; day-level Indiana DOE attendance × IHSAA varsity rosters; student fixed-effects causal model).

Athletics participation is rising — even as enrollment declines

- CA HS enrollment has declined 8 consecutive years (~1.3%/yr). CIF participation: **763,867 → 806,979 → 852,575 (2024-25 all-time high; +11.6% two-year)**.
- Athletics participation grew 11.6% over two years while California high school enrollment declined.

PRIMARY SOURCES

Malkus N, Hollon S. *An Extra Point for Attendance: The Impact of High School Varsity Athletics on Absenteeism*. American Enterprise Institute, April 8, 2026. aei.org/research-products/report/an-extra-point-for-attendance/. California Interscholastic Federation Annual Participation Census 2022–23 through 2024–25. California Department of Education *Current Expense of Education per ADA, FY 2023–24*. Voice of San Diego, *Grossmont Union's Layoffs Spark Outrage* (March 5, 2025) — context on declining enrollment and reserves. Full report:
JDAVIS-NETIZEN.GITHUB.IO/GUHSD-ATHLETICS-FUNDING-REPORT